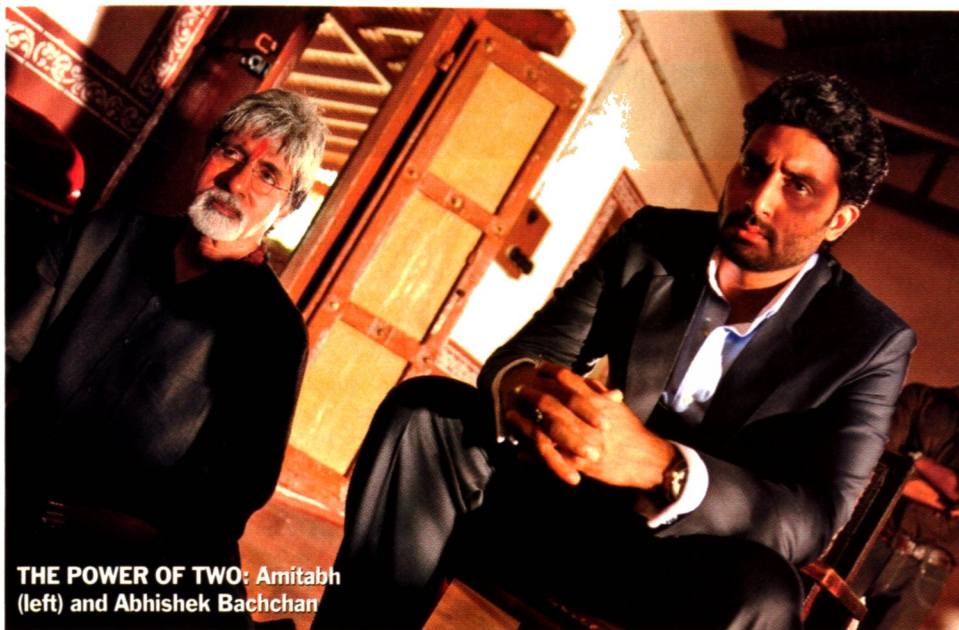




THE POWER OF TWO: Amitabh (left) and Abhishek Bachchan

film review The Raj Rules

Director: Ram Gopal Varma
Starring: Amitabh Bachchan, Abhishek Bachchan, Aishwarya Rai Bachchan

She turns around and says firmly, "*Ek chai dena.*" The camera freezes on her. It's an image that stays in a film replete with an amazing economy of gesture and control over speech. Aishwarya screaming silently into the camera, tears streaming down her face. Abhishek, even as he fights for his life, flailing about to protect his woman. Amitabh rolling up his sleeves above the elbow as he gets back to work. It's a meditation on Ram Gopal Varma's favourite subject, power. How it is grabbed and how it is retained. Its fascinating parallels with reality cannot escape the viewer, even if he is not a news channel junkie like Varma. There's the hot-headed Sanjay Somji, played by Marathi stage actor Rajesh Shringarpore,

modelled on the early Raj Thackeray, complete with spectacles and *gamcha*. There's the aging tiger Subhash Nagre (Amitabh), who controls the politics of the state despite rarely moving from his modest living room. There's the driven NRI woman heading a "*videshi*" power plant, an initially hard-as-nails Aishwarya channelling Rebecca Mark of Enron. There's also a remarkable similarity with the Family Bachchan, the fiercely protective Mufasa with his cubs Simba and Nala.

Varma keeps a tight rein over a plot that retains a complex level of suspense. There are several well-crafted homilies by writer Prashant Pandey—*nazdeeki nuksaan dekhne se pehle door ka fayda sochna chahiye* (short-term losses are necessary for long-term gains), or, *Hindustan mein logon ko development nahin*, entertainment *chahiye* (Indians don't want progress, they want fun). But ultimately the film derives its drama from the exchanges between the three main char-

acters, whether it is Abhishek awkwardly comforting his father on the absence of his elder brother (to remind us that it is a sequel) or Aishwarya reaching a hand out to Abhishek. The soundtrack is not intrusive (a major flaw with *Sarkar*) and the cross-referencing with *Godfather* is sporadic (a bomb in the car blows up a key character). The cinematography, in shades of sepia, by Varma loyalist Amit Roy, is outstanding. The low-angle shots give an intimacy to the audience and the play of light and shade is used to menacing effect. Could this be the beginning of a new representation of politics in Hindi cinema? One that is run like a well-oiled family firm, that doesn't occupy posts of public power, but works the backrooms? Varma may have painted a too-idealistic picture of their working—they care more about public good than those who rule—but he has created a movie that is absorbing and a heroine in Aishwarya who has tremendous possibilities for the future. *by Kaveri Banzal*

music reviews For the Love of God



Sehar

BHAKTI UTSAV

Every year, Sehar organises a bhakti festival, select live recordings from which are then released. Concerts from last year—including ecstatic qawwalis by Pakistani artistes Mehr and Sher Ali, Gurbani by Ustad Chand Afzal, Carnatic bhakti songs by Sanjay Subramaniam and a tribute to Lord Krishna by Sanjeev Abhayankar, a disciple of Pandit Jasraj—are a must for fans of devotional music. The highlight is the Paluskar gayaki by Vidhyadhar Vyas, who has sung *Payoji maine in raga jhinjhoti* and *Raghupati raghav raja ram*. A rare and moving collection of live performances.

TUM JO MILE



EMI
Rs 195

Music has the power to express the joy or sorrow ensconced in a lover's heart. In this compilation

of memorable love songs, A.R. Rahman pays an emotional tribute to emperor Shahjahan and Mumtaz with *Ek mohabbat*. *Aankhon ke sagar* by Pakistani band Fuzon is sung in the pop tradition, but based on raga yaman. Then are soft classical numbers sung by sarangi maestro Ustad Sultan Khan—*Piya basanti* with Chitra and *Kate nahin raat*. In the pop-thumri *Seekho na*, Shubha Mudgal tells the lover to understand the language of love through looks. Santoor player Abhay Sopori's *Tum bin neend*, Shaan's *Gunsam ho kyun* and Kailash Kher's *Dilruba* make an excellent mix for love-filled moments.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit